Seaweeds

Most of the food produced in the oceans is made by tiny phytoplankton that drift in open water. These microscopic algae have much bigger relatives that live in shallow, sunlit water. These are algae too, but we call them seaweeds. Although they look like plants, they are not true plants because they have a different internal structure. They must live underwater, but many are adapted for life on tidal shores.

MARINE ALGAE

Seaweeds are multi-celled marine relatives of the tiny single-celled algae that form much of the phytoplankton. They are both protists—living things that are neither animals nor plants. But like plants, they are able to absorb solar energy and use it to make sugar from water and carbon dioxide, a process called photosynthesis.

BUOYED UP

Since seaweeds need sunlight, they must grow near the water surface. Some float in the ocean, but most are attached to rocks on shallow seabeds and their flexible stems and leaflike fronds are buoyed up by the water. Many seaweeds have gas-filled floats to make sure the light-gathering fronds lie as near to the surface as possible.